

The WhatsApp number: what to do and what it costs

Revised after Dan's note about the QR code. Shorter answer than we first thought, and cheaper.

What we'd recommend

Plan A — exactly what you asked for. Buy a new WhatsApp number through Twilio and connect it to the Lead Centre. You never touch Facebook.

Dan's point about the QR code changes our advice. We'd assumed the van was bringing in a lot of WhatsApp enquiries and had suggested restickering it. Two enquiries in eight months says otherwise, so leave the van alone — it isn't worth the effort.

£5–10 a month, at the WhatsApp volume you're actually doing

1 Oct 2026 Affects every plan below. Replying to someone who messaged you first is **free** today; from 1 October Meta charges about 4p a reply. All the prices here are the after-October ones, so nothing jumps on you later.

The five plans

Twilio charges per message, so at low volume the bill is small. The other options are here so you can see we checked.

A **New number, van stays on Dan's phone** **DO THIS**

~£5–10/mo

Exactly what you asked for. New WhatsApp number through Twilio, wired into the app. The van's QR keeps going to the old number on Dan's phone, untouched.

WORKS WELL BECAUSE

- Nothing touches the number painted on the van — no risk at all
- Live in days, not weeks
- No porting, no waiting on Lycamobile
- You never open Facebook
- Cheapest of the lot

THE CATCH

- Anything that does come via the van QR stays on Dan's phone, outside the app
- On Dan's figures that's about one enquiry every four months, so not much of a loss
- You'd want to keep half an eye on the old number rather than forget it entirely

B **New number, and restick the van's QR to it** **NOT WORTH IT NOW**

~£5–10/mo + stickers

Same as A, then a sticker over the QR panel pointing at the new number. We suggested this before hearing Dan's numbers — at two enquiries in eight months, the QR isn't earning the effort.

WORKS WELL BECAUSE

- Everything WhatsApp would land in one place
- Still no porting and no Facebook
- A sticker on one panel is cheap next to a re-signwrite

THE CATCH

- Fixes a problem that on the evidence barely exists
- Leaflets already out still point at the old number anyway
- Cost and hassle of getting the vans done
- Only worth doing if the QR ever starts pulling its weight

C **Same, but through 360dialog instead of Twilio** **ONLY LATER**

~£45/mo

A WhatsApp specialist rather than a general provider. Flat monthly fee per number, and no mark-up on the message charges.

WORKS WELL BECAUSE

- Fee never grows, however many messages you send
- Genuinely cheaper past roughly 8,000 messages a month
- WhatsApp is all they do, so support knows it well

THE CATCH

- Roughly five times the cost at the volume you're actually doing
- You'd be paying a flat subscription to send a handful of messages
- No benefit you'd notice day to day

D Move the van's own number into the app

YOU'VE SAID NO

~£5–10/mo

What we'd originally discussed: take 07440 517077 off Lycamobile and connect it to a provider, so the QR and the leaflets keep working exactly as printed.

WORKS WELL BECAUSE

- Nothing to reprint or resticker — every leaflet stays correct
- One number, one inbox, from day one
- Tidiest end state of any option
- Doesn't need porting either — a provider can take it as it is

THE CATCH

- Connecting it **wipes access to that number's WhatsApp history** — not recoverable
- Dan loses it from his phone; it lives in the app instead
- A short risky window on your main lead source while it switches
- You've said you'd rather not, which is fair

E Aircall's own WhatsApp add-on

BLOCKED

Calls and WhatsApp with one supplier, on one bill, since you're taking Aircall for the phones anyway.

WORKS WELL BECAUSE

- One supplier, one bill, one place to ring when something breaks
- Neatest setup of the five, on paper

THE CATCH

- Needs a **verified** Meta account — company documents submitted to Facebook
- That's precisely the thing you've ruled out, so it's off the table for now
- Worth remembering if you ever change your mind

The more useful question now

Dan's note is the most valuable thing anyone's told us on this job. If the QR code has produced two enquiries in eight months, then we've been building around the wrong assumption — and it raises a better question: **where do your leads actually come from?**

Phone calls to the 0330? The website? Google? Word of mouth? Whatever the real answer is, that's what the Lead Centre should be wired into first. WhatsApp is worth having because it's cheap and easy, but it shouldn't be the priority if it's barely used.

If Dan can tell us roughly how last month's jobs came in, we'll aim the next piece of work at the channel that's actually earning.

And the one from before, still open

You mentioned the calls will come in on an Aircall number. But the van has **0330 133 9144** printed down the side of it.

Is that number moving across to Aircall, or is this a brand-new Aircall number? If it's new, then the phone number on the van and on the leaflets is wrong from day one — and honestly that's a bigger problem than anything on the WhatsApp side, because it's the number people ring.

Quick answer on that and we can sort the calls properly at the same time.

One thing to say no to

If anyone offers you a WhatsApp setup with *no* Meta involvement at all, it'll be a tool that logs in as a normal user. It breaks WhatsApp's rules and gets numbers banned with no appeal. On the number painted on your van, that would be unrecoverable. The legitimate off-the-shelf providers all deal with Meta for you — that's the difference.

Next steps

- 1 **Tell us which plan** — A is our recommendation, and B soon after. — Sam
- 2 **Answer the 0330 question** above. — Sam
- 3 **We confirm one thing with Twilio** before spending anything. — us
- 4 **We buy and connect the number**, registered to C1 so it's always yours. — us
- 5 **We test it properly** — real message in, real reply out, both on the same customer. — us
- 6 **You have a look**, then decide on the QR sticker. — Sam and Dan

Being straight with you about the numbers

The prices come from Twilio's, 360dialog's and Meta's published rates, so we're confident in those. What we can't tell from their websites is exactly how much of the Facebook side each one handles for you — and since that's the entire point of what you asked for, we'll confirm it on a call before spending a penny. If the answer is "you still have to send documents to Facebook", we move to the next provider and tell you.